Q+A

PACKING A PUNCH

With two World Championship gold medals under her belt, boxer **Nikhat Zareen** is looking forward to the Paris Olympics next year



Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q. How was this gold different from the one at the World Championships last year?

This year's World Championships were very meaningful. Firstly, the competition was in India and I was the face of the event, so I left no stone unturned in my preparation. Also, my opponents were tough. Then, I competed in a new weight category and had to cut an additional two kilos.

Q. From posters in the arena to the crowd chanting your name, how much pressure is there on you as the most recognised Indian boxer today?

I would say that the pressure I feel is positive because it motivates me a lot. The support from the home fans boosts my confidence. It was one of the major factors in my winning the gold medal.

Q. There were many challenges that you and your family had to face when you decided to take up boxing. What would you tell a young girl who dreams of becoming Nikhat Zareen someday?

I would advise the young girl to dream big and not be afraid of the challenge it presents. By stepping outside her comfort zone, she can take the necessary steps to become a champion.

Q. What would going to the 2024 Paris Olympics mean to you?

It is my ultimate dream, so it will be very special. It is this moment that I have worked very hard for over all these years. But going there is not enough. I have to come back with the yellow metal and I expect nothing less than that from myself.

with Shail Desai